

Introduction to Professional Nursing and Ethics

Course: Nursing Ethics and Professionalism

Definition of Nursing

- Nursing is the protection, promotion, and optimization of health and abilities.
- Involves prevention of illness, alleviation of suffering, and advocacy for individuals, families, and communities.
- Nursing encompasses clinical care, education, research, management, and public health services.

Nursing as a Profession

- Based on a body of specialized knowledge.
- Requires formal education, training, and continuing professional development.
- Guided by a code of ethics and professional standards.
- Provides service to humanity with accountability and integrity.

Historical Development of Nursing

- **Ancient times:** Care provided by family and community members.
- **Middle Ages:** Religious institutions played a major role.
- **19th Century:** Florence Nightingale – founder of modern nursing, emphasized hygiene and professional training.
- **20th Century onward:** Expansion of nursing education, research, and professional autonomy.

Roles and Functions of Nurses

- **Caregiver:** Provides holistic care to patients.
- **Advocate:** Protects patients' rights and interests.
- **Educator:** Teaches patients and families about health.
- **Manager:** Coordinates patient care and resources.
- **Researcher:** Contributes to evidence-based practice.
- **Collaborator:** Works with other health professionals.

Nursing Ethics

- **Ethics:** Moral principles guiding professional behavior.
- Ensures nurses make **right decisions** in patient care.
- Promotes **trust, safety, and accountability** in nursing practice.
- Core ethical principles: **Autonomy, Beneficence, Non-maleficence, Justice, Veracity & Fidelity.**

Summary

- Nursing is a **professional, ethical, and regulated practice.**
- Combines **knowledge, skills, and ethical principles** to provide quality care.
- Nurses are accountable to patients, society, and professional standards.

Legal Requirements for Nursing Practice

**Licensure,
Registration,
Certification, and
Accreditation**

Introduction

- Nursing is a regulated profession requiring legal authorization to practice.
- Government and professional councils ensure nurses meet standards of competence.
- Legal requirements protect patients and maintain professional accountability.

Licensure

- Licensure is the legal permission to practice nursing granted by a government authority.
- Ensures that the nurse meets minimum standards of competence.
- Required before practicing professionally.
- Example: Nursing and Midwifery Council license.

Registration

- Registration involves being listed on the official record of qualified nurses.
- Confirms educational preparation and competence.
- Registration precedes licensure but does not itself grant legal authority to practice.

Certification

- Certification is recognition of specialized knowledge or skills.
- Usually provided by professional associations or educational bodies.
- Examples: Critical care nursing, midwifery, community health nursing.

Accreditation

- Accreditation applies to institutions (nursing schools, hospitals).
- Confirms that the institution meets established educational or service standards.
- Ensures quality and consistency in nursing education and healthcare delivery.

Summary

- Licensure – Legal authority to practice.
- Registration – Entry into professional record.
- Certification – Specialized qualification.
- Accreditation – Institutional approval.
- → A nurse must obtain a license to legally practice.

Ethics in Nursing Practice

The Four Basic Ethical Principles

- Autonomy
- Beneficence
- Non-maleficence
- Justice

Autonomy

- Respect the patient's right to make decisions about their own care.
- Support patients in **expressing their preferences**.
- Encourage **informed decision-making** by providing necessary information.
- Recognize and honor the patient's **values, beliefs, and choices**.

Beneficence

- Act in the best interest of the patient and promote their well-being.
- Provide care that maximizes benefits and positive outcomes.
- Engage in compassionate, supportive, and proactive nursing practices.
- Balance patient needs with resources and clinical judgment

Non-maleficence

- Avoid causing harm to patients.
- Minimize risks and prevent errors in care.
- Ensure safe practices and interventions.
- Recognize situations that could lead to harm and take preventive action.

Justice

- Treat all patients fairly and equitably.
- Ensure equal access to healthcare regardless of background, status, or beliefs.
- Advocate for fairness in resource allocation and care delivery.
- Promote social justice in healthcare policies and practices.

Ethical Decision-Making in Nursing

- Ethical dilemmas occur when values or principles conflict.
- **Steps in ethical decision-making:**
 - Identify the ethical issue.
 - Gather relevant information.
 - Consider ethical principles and professional codes.
 - Explore alternatives and possible outcomes.
 - Decide and act ethically.
 - Evaluate the results.

Patients' Rights and Advocacy

- Patients are entitled to **dignity, privacy, and informed participation** in care.
- Nurses act as **advocates** to protect patient rights.
- **Responsibilities include:**
 - Ensuring informed consent.
 - Maintaining confidentiality.
 - Speaking up against unsafe or unethical practices.
 - Supporting vulnerable and marginalized patients.

Patients' Rights

- **Right to Autonomy and Informed Consent:**
Patients have the right to make decisions about their care after receiving complete and understandable information.
- **Right to Freedom from Unnecessary Detention:**
Patients cannot be kept in a healthcare facility against their will once they are medically cleared.
- **Right to Dignity and Equitable Treatment:**
All patients must be treated with respect and fairness, regardless of financial status, ethnicity, or background.
- **Right to Confidentiality and Privacy:**
Patients' personal health information must be protected and shared only with authorized personnel.

COMMON VIOLATION OF PATIENT RIGHTS

- **Abandonment of care**
- **No dignified care**
- **Detention in facility**
- **Non-consented care**

A. Abandonment of care

- This occurs when a healthcare provider who has a responsibility for a patient's care leaves them without making reasonable arrangements for the continuation of that care, especially at a critical moment. This is a violation of the right to appropriate healthcare and can lead to significant harm.

B. No dignified care

- This involves any treatment that undermines a person's self-respect, such as intentional humiliation, scolding, shouting, or rough handling. The right to dignity and respect is a fundamental human right in healthcare.

C. Detention in facility

- This involves confining a person (e.g., a mother or infant) in a health facility, often due to the inability to pay user fees. Arbitrary detention is a clear violation of human rights.

D. Non-consented care

- This refers to any examination, intervention, or treatment performed without the patient's informed consent. This violates the patient's autonomy and right to make free decisions about their own body, and in a legal context can be considered assault.

Professional Conduct and Accountability

- Professional conduct reflects **nursing values and ethical standards**.
- **Accountability** means being responsible for one's actions and decisions.
- **Nurses must:**
 - Follow professional codes and legal standards.
 - Maintain competence through lifelong learning.
 - Report unethical or unsafe behavior.
 - Practice within the legal and professional scope.

Summary

- Nursing ethics guide decision-making and professional behavior.
- Core principles: **autonomy, beneficence, non-maleficence, and justice.**
- Nurses must **advocate for patients** and remain **accountable** in all aspects of care.

Legal Responsibilities and Liabilities of Nurses

- Nurses are legally responsible for the care they provide.
- Must follow **laws, regulations, and professional standards.**
- Liable for actions that cause harm due to **negligence or misconduct.**
- Must act within their **scope of practice** and maintain **competence.**

Negligence and Malpractice

- **Negligence:** Failure to provide care that a reasonable nurse would provide.
- **Malpractice:** Professional misconduct or failure to meet accepted standards.
- Can lead to legal action and disciplinary measures.
- Prevention includes proper training, adherence to protocols, and ethical practice.

Documentation and Confidentiality

- Accurate documentation is essential for legal protection and patient safety.
- Confidentiality protects patient privacy and trust.
- Nurses must maintain records of care and safeguard sensitive information.
- Breaches can result in legal and professional consequences.

Nurse–Patient Relationship and Informed

- Build a therapeutic, professional relationship based on trust and respect.
- **Informed consent:** Patients must receive clear information about procedures, risks, and benefits.
- Nurses ensure patients understand and voluntarily agree to care.
- Supports autonomy and legal protection.

Professional Standards and Codes

- **Nursing Code of Ethics:** Guides moral and professional behavior.
- **Professional Standards and Competencies:** Define expected skills and conduct.
- **Continuing Professional Development (CPD):** Maintains knowledge, skills, and competence.
- Ensures high-quality and ethical patient care.

Professional Organizations

- **National and International Nursing Associations:** Support nurses professionally and advocate for health policies.
- **Roles of Professional Bodies:**
 - Regulate and license nurses.
 - Set educational and practice standards.
 - Promote professional development and advocacy.
 - Represent nurses' interests in healthcare policy and legislation.

Summary

- Nurses must comply with legal requirements and professional standards.
- Ethical and competent practice reduces risk of negligence and malpractice.
- Documentation, confidentiality, and informed consent are essential.
- Professional organizations support nurses and regulate the profession

